

BEN ROCHFORD

Department of Sociology, Duke University
2200 West Main Street (Suite 700), Durham, NC 27705

EDUCATION

2023 - Present	Ph.D. Candidate in Sociology, Duke University
2023 - 2026	M.A. in Sociology, Duke University
2019 - 2023	B.S. in Computer Science, Georgia Institute of Technology <i>Highest Honor</i>

RESEARCH AREAS

Artificial Intelligence and Society	Social Psychology
Political Polarization	Mental Health

PUBLICATIONS

Marie Neubrandner*, Markus Reiter-Haas*, **Ben Rochford**, Maxwell B. Allamong, Chris Bail, D. Sunshine Hillygus, Alexander Volfovsky. (2026). *Can Platform Design Encourage Curiosity? Evidence from an Independent Social Media Experiment*. Forthcoming.

Ben Rochford, Cathy Lee, Michelle Qiu, Alexander Volfovsky, D. Sunshine Hillygus, Christopher Bail. (2025) *A Sociological Turing Test: Social Identity Cues Shape Who is Classified as Human Online*. R&R.

Sachin Pendse, **Ben Rochford**, Neha Kumar, Munmun De Choudhury. (2025) *The Role of Partisan Culture in Mental Health Language Online*. ACM Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW), 2025.

Ben Rochford, Sachin Pendse, Neha Kumar, and Munmun De Choudhury. (2023) "Leveraging Symptom Search Data to Understand Disparities in US Mental Health Care: Demographic Analysis of Search Engine Trace Data." JMIR Mental Health, 10, e43253

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Mapping the Development of Cultural Backlash Against AI Slop Content

Co-authors: *Richard Jean So, Hoyt Long, Zini Zhang*

Will We Offload Moral Judgments to AI Systems?

Sole author. The Polarization Lab, Duke University

Do Social Identities Shape Trust of AI Systems?

Co-author: *Alexander Tolkin*. The Polarization Lab, Duke University

How do interactions with chatbots shape understanding of current events?

Co-author: *Alexander Tolkin*. The Polarization Lab, Duke University

People to Prompts: Does Interview Data Improve LLM Survey Simulations for Underrepresented Groups?

Co-authors: *Lorcan Neill, David Gonzales Chavez, Christopher Bail*

Duke University; University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

PRESENTATIONS

- 2025** “AI and Social Problems” – Invited Lecture, Duke Explainable AI course, Fall 2025
- 2025** “A Sociological Turing Test” – Roundtable presentation
Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Chicago, Illinois
- 2025** “Very Human Biases in Human AI Interaction” – Invited lecture
Summer Institute in Computational Social Science, Lake Como, Italy
- 2025** “Bot or Not? Identity Biases in the Perceived Humanity of Online Profiles” – Oral presentation
Responsible AI Symposium 2025, Duke University, Durham, NC
- 2025** “Identity cues impact perceptions of online accounts as artificial” – Roundtable presentation
Tar Devils (Duke-UNC Sociology Symposium), Durham, NC
- 2024** “The Role of Partisan Culture in Mental Health Language Online” – Oral presentation
International Conference on Computational Social Science 2024 (IC2S2), Philadelphia, PA
- 2022** “Using Symptom Search Data to Understand Disparities in U.S. Mental Healthcare” – Poster
ACM conference on Equity and Access in Algorithms, Mechanisms, and Optimization (EAAMO), Washington, DC
- 2022** “Symptom Search and Unequal Access to Mental Healthcare” – Oral presentation
Georgia Tech Undergraduate Research Symposium, Atlanta, GA

EXPERIENCE

Graduate Fellow, Society-Centered AI August 2025 - Present
Duke University

Lead Program Assistant August 2024 - Present
Summer Institutes in Computational Social Science, Tech for Open Minds (Global)

Graduate Researcher August 2023 - Present
Polarization Lab, Duke University

Summer Institutes in Computational Social Science July 2024

University of Pennsylvania, 2024 Cohort

Undergraduate Researcher

Social Dynamics and Well-being Lab, Georgia Institute of Technology

January 2021 - May 2023

Software Engineering Intern, Full Stack

Workforce Intelligence, Pegasystems

May 2021 - August 2021

Data Engineering Intern

Shenandoah Telecommunications Company

June 2020 - August 2020

LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

Co-Chair, Graduate Student Forum

Duke Sociology

2026 - Present

Organizer, Invited Lecturer

SICSS: Lake Como, Italy

July 2025

Volunteer, GPSG Community Pantry

Duke University

2025 - Present

Board Member, Duke Wesley Foundation

Duke University

2025 - Present

Section Leader, Georgia Tech Marching Band

Georgia Institute of Technology

2021 - 2023

President, Georgia Tech Wesley Foundation

Georgia Institute of Technology

2022

Eagle Scout, Boy Scouts of America

Troop 30, Staunton, VA

2018

SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

Graduate Research Fellowship Program – Honorable Mention

National Science Foundation

2025

SAGE Research Spotlight Interviewee

ASA Annual Meeting

2025

Institutional Fellowship

Duke University

2023 - 2025

LaRoche Merit Scholarship

Georgia Institute of Technology

2019 - 2023

Outstanding Student Leader

Georgia Institute of Technology

2023

REFERENCES

Dr. Christopher Bail (*Ph.D. advisor*)
Duke University
Christopher.Bail@duke.edu

Dr. Lynn Smith-Lovin
Duke University
SmithLov@duke.edu

Dr. Munmun De Choudhury (*B.S. advisor*)
Georgia Institute of Technology
Munmun.Choudhury@cc.gatech.edu

Dr. Jennifer Hasler
Georgia Institute of Technology
Jennifer.Hasler@ece.gatech.edu